

ALL HANDS ON DECK
AAP's Arvind Kejriwal at a roadshow in Chotila, Surendranagar, Nov. 6

KEJRIWAL'S 'GUARANTEES'

- Free education, healthcare at state institutions
- **300** units free electricity a month
- **Rs 1,000** allowance to women above 18
- **1 million** new govt jobs; recruitment schedule announced
- Farm loan waiver up to **Rs 2 lakh**; free daytime electricity
- **80%** quota for local youth in private sector jobs
- **Rs 3,000** a month allowance to unemployed youth
- **Rs 10,000** salary for sarpanches
- **Rs 10 lakh** to village panchayat via direct transfer
- Village computer entrepreneurs (VCEs) to get **Rs 20,000** salary

ate was 24 million in 1990, when the Congress last ruled. It is 49 million in 2022. About 50 per cent of the voters have no memory of the much pilloried Congress rule. That said, a conscious BJP has responded to almost every issue raised by AAP through it own sops and use of the government machinery. The narrative of voting for *aapdo manas* (our man) Modi—who promises to make India a global superpower—has been used in three elections since 2014. Will it work again this time?

The BJP is not taking any chances and is vowing to do its best ever. At a poll rally in Kaprada in tribal-dominated Valsad, PM Modi thundered, "*Aa Gujarat mein banavyu chhe* (We have made this Gujarat)...I want to break my own record this time. Bhupendra's record should be higher than Narendra's." Modi has conducted four whirlwind tours of the state, twice in October itself, and inaugurated new projects worth Rs 65,000 crore. The BJP's highest seat tally is 127 seats in the 2002 election following the communal wave after the Godhra riots.

Meanwhile, here are two possible scenarios if AAP does make an impact:

AAP gets a 7-15 per cent vote share: Grudgingly, even the BJP and Congress admit this is a likely scenario. Experienced poll observers say if the "real issues" are on voters' minds on polling day, it will be closer to 15 per cent. The question, of course, is where does this vote come from? The Congress, possibly, as the party has been losing vote share to the BJP. Poll pundits claim the Congress has a loyal vote base of 35 per cent (50-60 seats) and everything above that depends on "seasonal factors". So AAP could possibly wean away the stray 6.4 per cent vote share from the Congress's 2017 tally (41.4 per cent). In this scenario, analysts believe AAP may win up to five seats.

The Congress's loyal vote base is in the tribal areas, a section of the OBCs (mainly Kolis) and the Muslims. AAP has made no overt outreach to the Muslim community, though it has announced two Muslim candidates in Ahmedabad's Jamalpur and Dariapur seats. Muslims make up 9-10 per cent of the electorate and are estimated to have an impact in 53 seats. However, with the AIMIM (All India Majlis-e-Ittehadul Muslimeen) also in the fray, their vote will be divided, resulting in a significant loss to the Congress. AAP explored a tie-up with